Iranian-linked hacker group targets Iran International journalists in cyberattack

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CPJ Staff July 9, 2025

Paris, July 9, 2025—Hackers linked with Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) infiltrated the Telegram accounts of current and former staff of the outlet Iran International in a targeted campaign to intimidate and silence journalists, the London-based broadcasterreported Tuesday.

The breaches were linked to two coordinated attacks – one in the summer of 2024 and another in January 2025 – that used malware-laced Telegram messages to infect staff devices, DW Persian reported.

"The use of spyware to harass journalists represents a chilling escalation in Iran's campaign to intimidate and silence independent media," said CPJ Regional Director Sara Qudah. "No journalist should be subjected to digital surveillance or coercion. Iran must immediately cease its transnational repression of the press."

The operation was attributed to Banished Kitten, also known as Storm-0842, Dune, or Handala, a cyber unit within Iran's Ministry of Intelligence led by Yahya Hosseini Panjkhi, whose identity was first revealed by the outlet's reporting.

Outlets reported that the hacker group Handala claimed responsibility for the attack. The group has not confirmed the claim on any of its affiliated platforms.

The outlet said it has strengthened digital security and alerted authorities following both attacks.

“We remain resolute in our mission to deliver accurate, uncensored news to our audience, and we will not allow these threats — online or offline — to disrupt our work. These attempts to intimidate us will not succeed,” the channel added.

Separately, Iranian lawmakers are considering a bill that press freedom advocates warn could criminalize independent journalism tied to foreign outlets as it imposes harsh penalties, including death, for alleged collaboration with “hostile” states or media. It would also allow courts to jail journalists and bar them from public service if their reporting is deemed to cause “fear and panic” or harm “national security.”

CPJ’s email to the Iranian mission to the United Nations in New York requesting comment on the cyberattacks and the proposed law did not receive a response.

Editor’s note: *The fourth and fifth paragraphs were updated to correct the spelling of Handala.*